

fridayReview

THE HINDU

On a musical trail

Revisiting the temples behind Dikshitar's 'Kodandaramam' composition **p2**

The seed of creativity

Malavika Sarukkai explores contemporary narratives in her new work, 'Beeja' **p3**



THREADS OF EMPOWERMENT

American textile expert Judy Frater made Kutch her home to support Rabari craftsmanship **p4**

ILLUSTRATION: SAAI



Karthik Bhatt

Tamil theatre was actively involved in raising funds for various charitable and public causes, thanks to the huge patronage it enjoyed. Many theatre groups staged dramas, the proceeds of which were used for educational institutions, hospitals, benefit funds and calamity reliefs. During World War II, the Madras Governor's War Fund greatly benefitted by the staging of several Tamil plays. For instance, M.K. Thyagaraja Bhagavathar's performance of *Pavalakkodi* in 1941 at Sun Theatre in T. Nagar raised a sum of ₹ 7,000 which was donated to the cause. One of the prominent institutions to have been immensely supported by Tamil theatre was the Ramakrishna Mission Students' Home in Mylapore – thanks to the efforts of C. Ramanujachariar.

Born in 1875, Ramanujachariar graduated with a BA from the Presidency College and joined the Madras Secretariat as a clerk. While still in college, he became part of the group of followers who gathered around Swami Vivekananda during the latter's stay in Madras in early 1893, before he left for Chicago to participate in the Parliament of World Religions. When Vivekananda was given a grand reception in the city in February

On World Theatre Day, a look at how C. Ramanujachariar's drama troupe funded social causes through plays

The act of giving

1897 upon his return from the West, Ramanujachariar got an opportunity to closely interact with him and was drawn into the Ramakrishna movement.

When Swami Ramakrishnananda, who was sent by Swami Vivekananda to spread the message of Sri Ramakrishna in South India, came to Madras in March 1897,

Ramanujachariar became one of his ardent supporters. In 1905, Ramanujachariar's cousin C. Ramaswamy Iyengar was moved by the plight of four boys from Guntur who had come to the city seeking help for their studies but found none. This gave the impetus for the founding of a home to provide free boarding and

lodging for indigent students coming to the city for their studies, and thus was born the Ramakrishna Mission Students' Home, with the blessings and guidance of Swami Ramakrishnananda.

Ramanujachariar became closely involved with the activities of the Home since its inception and after Ramaswamy Iyengar's demise in 1932 became its secretary.

In 1917, Ramanujachariar founded a drama troupe called the Madras Secretariat Party, comprising his colleagues, to use theatre to support charitable causes, particularly the Students' Home and the Ramakrishna Math. Ramanujachariar was the director, lead actor and composer – all rolled into one. When Swami Brahmananda, the first president of the Ramakrishna Order, came to Madras on three occasions, Ramanujachariar used the proceeds of a benefit drama to purchase the land on which the old shrine of the Mylapore Math stands today. During his 1921 visit, Swami Brahmananda watched a performance of *Mira Bai* staged by the Madras Secretariat Party at the Victoria Public Hall, in which Ramanujachariar played the part of Rana. Later, on Swami's suggestion, Ramanujachariar translated and performed the Bengali drama *Bilvamangal* in Tamil.

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A CH-CHE



Song and sojourn Kodandaramaswami temple in Vaduvur; (below) Entrance to the Kodandarama temple on the banks of the Vennar in Thanjavur. PHOTOS: B. VELANKANNI RAJ AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT; ILLUSTRATION BY SOUMYADIP SINHA



When Rama inspired Dikshitar

Revisiting the Thanjavur temples linked to the composer’s ‘Kodandaramam’ kriti

Sriram V.

Sometime in the early 19th century, Muthuswami Dikshitar arrived in Thanjavur for an extended stay. Legend suggests he may have visited even earlier, going by his composition ‘Nabhomani chandragni nayanam’ (Nabhomani raga, Triputa tala), which is believed to have been created on the occasion of the Brihadeeswara temple’s consecration during the reign of Serfoji II. The charanam line ‘Sarabhendra samsevitā charanam’ seems to indicate this. As per the Thanjavur Saraswathi Mahal Library records, the consecration took place in 1801, evidencing Dikshitar’s presence in the region.

The composer’s more prolonged stay was to teach music to the Thanjavur Quartet. According to Subbarama Dikshitar’s *Sangita Sampradaya Pradarsini*, only two of the four brothers, Ponniah and Vadivelu, were disciples of

Muthuswami Dikshitar. Today, it is accepted that all four trained under him. Since Vadivelu was born in 1810 and would have been around five when he began learning from Dikshitar, we can assume that the composer came to Thanjavur around 1815. During his stay, Dikshitar embarked on what may be described as raganga raga



project. As is well known, he followed the *asampurna mela/raganga raga* scheme, wherein a raga can be considered a parent scale if it has all seven notes, not necessarily in linear order or in both ascent and descent. It was scholar V. Raghavan who identified most of the compositions in this set, and the temples in and around Thanjavur mentioned in the lyrics. Of the 72 *raaganga* ragas, 69 have songs, all of them based on Thanjavur temples. Most of them are on the Big Temple and the Bangaru Kamakshi shrine.

One of the compositions is on Lord Rama – ‘Kodandaramam’ in raga *Kokilaravam* (the 11th *raaganga* raga in *Adi tala*). In keeping with most of the *raaganga* compositions, this too is set in the *pallavi/anupallavi* format, and therefore has no *charanam*. In recent times, this song has been attributed to the Rama temple at Vaduvur, known for its beautiful *utsava* deity. But according to V. Raghavan,

it was composed on the Kodandarama temple on the banks of the Vennar in Thanjavur.

There is logic in what he says, because the farthest temple to have a composition in the *raganga raga* scheme is the *Dharmasamvardhini* shrine in Tiruvārūr. All the temples featured in the set come under the administration of the Thanjavur Palace Devasthanam. However, the Vaduvur shrine has never been a part of it, making its association with the song unlikely. Having accepted V. Raghavan’s premise, the task then is to identify the temple he meant.

The shrine in question is an extremely picturesque one, not far from the famed *Punnainallur Mariamman* temple. The Vennar flows close by, but the larger water body in the vicinity is the *Samuthiram* lake. Given Thanjavur’s flat terrain, the temple’s *gopuram* and that of the *Mariamman* shrine can be seen from quite a distance. The *Kothandarama* temple can be reached by a road that runs past the now-ruined *Rani Mandapam*, once a pleasure pavilion for the Maratha queens.

The Vaduvur temple was built by *Pratapasingha* (1740-1763). Interestingly, his queen *Yamunamba* endowed another Rama temple at *Needamangalam*, whose presiding deity, *Santanaramaswami*, has been praised by Dikshitar in the kriti ‘*Santana ramaswaminam*’ in raga *Hindola Vasantam*. In this composition, Dikshitar refers to the *kshetra* as *Yamunambapuri*, indicating

the queen’s patronage.

A flight of steps takes you to the entrance arch of the Kodandarama temple in Vaduvur. The rectangular structure of the temple comprises the sanctum, a *mukhamandapam* and a spacious *circumambulatory* corridor. A colonnaded verandah with a raised platform runs all along the periphery, allowing devotees to sit and witness temple festivals. It also serves as a *vahana* *mandapam*.

Legend has it that the *utsava* idols of the temple – Rama, *Lakshmana*, *Sita* and *Anjaneya* – were discovered in a field, leading to the construction of the shrine. The *moolavar* is a magnificent standing *Kodandarama*, with *Lakshmana*, *Sita* and, most unusually, *Sugriva*. *Hanuman*, in *veera* posture, has a south-facing sanctum. There is another *Hanuman* idol outside this sanctum. A *Garuda* faces the main Rama. The priests here say that the *moola* Rama is made of *Salagrama* stone brought from *Nepal*, though it is more likely that it is fashioned in *stucco*, with *Salagrama* forming the core.

The tranquil ambience of the temple makes you imagine Dikshitar sitting here and composing *kritis*. That said, the composition does not give any *kshetra* details, and so the argument that it cannot be on Vaduvur stays. But then, none of the *raaganga raga* compositions provides any local details.

Irrespective of whether the song was composed here, the temple with its exquisite carvings and ornate *garbagriha* is worth a visit.

CALENDAR

Melange of music

Chennai Fine Arts celebrates the 16th year of *Dasarathi Sangeetotsavam*, a series of concerts as part of *Sri Ramanavami*, from March 28 to 31, at *Sri Krishna Mandiram*, *Tiruvannamiyur*.

The four-day festival begins with *Madhura Rangarajan*’s vocal recital. This will be followed by vocalist *Hemmige S. Prashanth*’s performance. Events to take place on other days are: March 29: Students of *Sowparnika Sangeetha Vidyalayam* will present ‘*Ramadasu Navarathna kritis*’ at 5 p.m. followed by *K. Bhaskaran*’s flute recital with his flautist-son *Nandan* at 6 p.m. March 30, 5 p.m.: Performance by the students of *Vani Sangeetha Gurukulam*, under the guidance of *Radha Bhaskar*, followed by *Swetaranyam Sisters*’ vocal concert at 6 p.m.

The festival concludes on March 31 with a *veena* performance by the students of *Oppilal School of Music*, Chennai at 5 p.m. *Divyaprabhanda Pannisai* led by *M. Kotilingam*, anchored by *S. Seethalakshmi*, will take place at 6 p.m. They will be accompanied by *S. Nithyasree* on the *veena* and *Madheswaran* on the *mridangam*.

Ramanavami special

Sri Thyaga Brahma Gana Sabha, *Vani Mahal*, celebrates *Sri Ramanavami* at *Sri Chandrasekarendra Saraswathi Mahaswami auditorium* from March 26 to April 7. Chief guest *Thangam Meganathan*, chairperson, *Rajalakshmi Institutions*, will confer the title ‘*Pravachana Sudha Vani*’ upon *Sanskrit scholar M.A. Venkatakrishnan* and ‘*Pravachana Yuva Vani*’ upon *Vārsha Bhuvaneshwari* on March 29 at 6 p.m. The awards have been instituted in memory of *Thangam Meganathan*’s father *P.A. Ramakrishnan*.

Hamsadhwani will present ‘*Sitaya Charitham Mahat*’, a special *Katha Kutcheri* today at 6.15 p.m. featuring *Dr. Sudha Seshayyan*’s discourse with *Gayathri Girish*’s vocal. They will be accompanied by *Mudicondan Ramesh* on the *veena* and *Shertalai Ananthakrishnan* on the *mridangam*. Venue: *Youth Hostel*, *Adyar*.

Movement and dialogue

Natyarangam, the dance wing of *Narada Gana Sabha* presents ‘*He Is My Slave*’ - *Of Movement & Meter*’ on March 28 at 6 p.m. The evening will feature *Alarmel Valli* and *Arundhathi Subramaniam* in conversation with *P.C. Ramakrishna*. Venue: *Narada Gana Sabha mini hall*.



A grand finale

The valedictory function of *Sri Parthasarathy Swami Sabha*’s annual dance festival, which was inaugurated on January 3, will take place on March 29, 5.30 p.m., at *Narada Gana Sabha*.

Art patron *Nalli Kuppusami Chetti* will preside. *Bharatanatyam* exponent *Sudharani Raghupathy*, the chief guest, will present the ‘*Kala Sarathy*’ title to senior *Bharatanatyam* dancer *Priyadarsini Govind*. Senior *Bharatanatyam* dancer *Meenakshi Chitharanjan* will be the guest of honour.

The evening also includes the presentation of certificates to best performers and the staging of *Sridevi Nrithyalaya*’s thematic production ‘*Ekdasa Vishnum*’ choreographed by *Sheela Unnikrishnan*, at 6.30 p.m.



Comforting steps

Young Bharatanatyam dancer Nivritii Mahesh on how her life found a new rhythm with a Cochlear implant

Deepa Venkatraman

The stage was set with a camera mounted on a tripod aimed at the *nattuvangam* artiste, its live-feed visible on a small monitor positioned at the stage level, just a few feet away from the performance area. Seventeen-year-old *Bharatanatyam* dancer *Nivritii Mahesh*, exuding confidence and poise, commenced her recital with a *Gambhira Nattai Ganesha* invocation. She followed it up with a rigorous *Simhendra madhyamam varnam*, a *Chandrakauns keerthanam*, *Shama padam*, and a lively *Sindhuhairavi thillana* with steady grace. Her recital was part of *Naada Sparsh* programme, presented by *SciArtsRUs* under their

initiative – *Artabilities 4 All*. The venue was *Narada Gana Sabha*’s mini hall.

Watching the seamless flow of her dance, it would be difficult to imagine that *Nivritii* was born with hearing impairment. She dances using bilateral cochlear implants – electronic devices in both ears that help her perceive sound.

Throughout her recital, *Nivritii* worked closely with her mother and guru, *Aishwarya Chakravarthy*, who provided her with rhythmic cues and also handled the *nattuvangam*. Her *nattuvangam* was captured on camera and streamed on to the stage monitor for *Nivritii* to follow, while sound engineer *Nambukumar Krishnan* fine-tuned the audio balance. The accompanists – vocalist *Srikanth Gopalakrishnan*,



Sound of silence Nivritii Mahesh. PHOTO: B. VELANKANNI RAJ

violinist *R. Kalaiarasan* and *mridangist N.K. Kesavan* supported the young dancer with sensitivity.

Nivritii’s story of resilience and passion reflects the determination of both the mother and the daughter. Their collaborative spirit transforms challenges into a celebration of music and movement. After cochlear implant surgery in the U.S. in 2012, *Nivritii* was able to hear and speak for the first time at age five. Recalling her initiation into *Bharatanatyam*, she says, “Soon after the surgery, I attended my mother’s dance classes, and later, enjoyed listening to stories of *Krishna*

and *Ganesha*. My mother asked me to write the stories and lyrics of the songs several times. To deepen my understanding, she would show me videos of these stories on *YouTube*.”

After a few years, she became part of the group dance presentations choreographed by her mother. Over time, challenges arose. The cochlear implants “helped me hear speech, but not all the tones and layers of live rhythmic and melodic instruments. The *mridangam*’s beats were sometimes too strong, and other external sounds interfered. This made it almost impossible to follow the

orchestra’s rhythm and melody. The variety of sounds was overwhelming,” says *Nivritii*.

It was during this time that her mother *Aishwarya* turned to technological support to help her daughter overcome these challenges. She, along with sound engineer *Nick Powell*, built a dual-channel audio system connected to her cochlear implant receiver. *Nivritii* explains, “One audio channel transmitted a custom-balanced orchestra mix, where critical rhythmic cues such as the *nattuvangam* and vocal counts were amplified, while less-essential instruments were softened. A

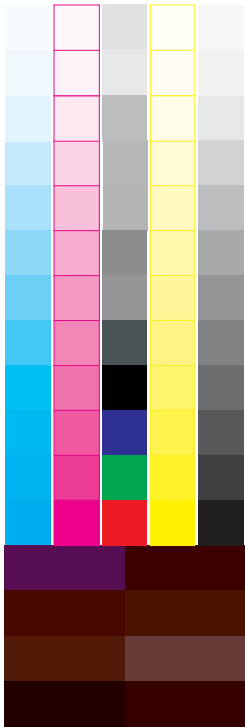
second private channel allowed my mother to provide live counts and guidance directly to me when needed.” Additional visual support, using a monitor, helped *Nivritii* follow her mother’s rhythmic cues and *nattuvangam*, in case she lost the beat.

When her mother suggested that she opt for a shared *arangetram* last June, *Nivritii* had other plans. “It’s a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity, and I was determined to present a solo *arangetram*. Though not easy, I was keen to preserve the traditional stage arrangement, with the instrumentalists and vocalists seated to the side,” she says. Senior artistes *Madurai R. Muralidharan* and *Renjith Babu* and *Vijna Vasudevan* helped *Nivritii* with her *arangetram* repertoire. “*Muralidharan* sir choreographed most of the pieces to suit my calibre. *Renjith anna* and *Vijna akka* mentored me on easy techniques to understand the compositions and strengthen choreography retention.”

Nivritii credits *Bharatantayam* for instilling positivity and purpose. “The stories my mother narrated from the *Puranas* to deepen my understanding of *bhakti* have been my source of strength, enabling me to embrace challenges,” says

Nivritii, a staunch believer in the *Bhagavad Gita*.

Nivritii plans to further use technology by exploring tools that can support her practice. “Through *SciArtsRUs*, a non-profit organisation, I am planning to work with haptic technology (touch-based vibration feedback) to help me internalise rhythm and movement more deeply, and to share *Bharatanatyam* with people who experience sound differently,” shares *Nivritii*.



Seed of change

In Malavika Sarukkai's 'Beeja', Bharatanatyam becomes a mirror to a troubled world



Creative zone
Malavika Sarukkai at the rehearsal space in her home; and (below) at a performance. PHOTOS: B. VELANKANNI RAJ & G. RAMAKRISHNA

Chitra Swaminathan
chitra.swaminathan@thehindu.co.in

Being on stage under the spotlight and enjoying the adoration of the audience is an experience artistes cherish. But what goes behind creating these moments of glory often remains unseen – it's in the privacy of the rehearsal space, behind the quiet walls that a performance takes shape over many hours of practice.

"I have spent most part of my life here," says celebrated dancer-choreographer Malavika Sarukkai, sitting on the wooden swing in the aesthetic and airy rehearsal area of her house in Valmiki Nagar. A part of it opens to the sky, and you can spot an old bougainvillea tree standing like a silent spectator. A huge mirror on the wall reflects her movements and expressions, while beautiful idols of Nataraja and Dakshinamurthy lend a divine touch. Located in the centre of the house, the space bridges the world of visitors with the private quarters of the dancer, as if drawing a subtle link between the outer and the inner realms.

"When I practise with the orchestra, this space resonates

Unique soundscape

The music composition is by Rajkumar Bharathi, with light design by Niranjan Gokhale. Sai Shrivananam, music producer and sound designer, has created a 3D bubble using an ambisonic soundscape — an uncommon feature in an Indian classical dance production. He has also incorporated instruments such as the frame drum, Chinese bawo, cello, sitar, and tabla, which are rarely used in Bharatanatyam orchestras. In addition to the pre-recorded score, mridangist Nellai Balaji and vocalist Krithika Aravind will perform live.

with sound and energy. Yet, there are times when I love to sit here alone, particularly when I am working on a production," says Malavika, as she prepares to stage her new work 'Beeja – Earth Seed' in Chennai.

Tracing the seed of joy that has turned into despair because of the destruction humans have unleashed on fellow beings and Nature, the production emerges as a poignant commentary on the

contemporary world, now caught in disastrous conflict. "With every performance of the work (previously staged in Mumbai, Delhi, Ahmedabad, Bengaluru and Washington DC), the unrest unfolding around us comes into sharper focus, reshaping the emotional undertones of my art, which is a lived response to the world I inhabit. At such times, art must move beyond beauty, becoming a powerful tool to heal minds,



grapple with loss and inspire people to replace hatred with love and empathy," says Malavika, explaining the genesis of 'Beeja'.

Looking at the world through an artistic lens is not new for Malavika, who began using the dance form to connect audiences with larger issues. "Of course, to begin with, you must master the vocabulary and repertoire. Once I felt ready to chart my own course, I used the technique of the *margam* to create works that resonated with me, and eventually with people as well. When you truly believe in what you want to create, it does gain a distinct flavour. I wanted my dance to be restrained, immersed in stylisation and infused with a certain spark. If you ask me what it feels like to dance, I would say, it is liberating."

Standing at the cusp of 50 years of dancing, Malavika remains a curious choreographer, determined to take her art to places she wants it to travel to. "But this effort does not stop with ideation. You must explore boldly, giving your imagination the wings it deserves. As I recently said at a lec-dem at the Bangalore International Centre, you have to think in terms of history, culture, music, lighting, costume, movement and expression – and all of these must come together," she explains.

This is the reason Malavika launched the Kalavaahini Trust – to mentor young enthusiasts. Having gained immensely from her art, she was keen to give something back. "As the Trust completes 10 years, I feel even more enthused to share my insights with youngsters. I hope they embrace the art not as imitation but as discovery and bring their creativity to stage through the Kalavaahini annual dance festival," says Malavika.

In 'Beeja', the great Banyan Tree stands as a sentinel from the past, bearing witness as the piece unravels themes of passion, greed and aggression. It reminds one of the bougainvillea, Malavika's steadfast companion during rehearsals, showcasing the need to hold on to endearing aspects of life amid constant change.

It was a tree that inspired Malavika to create 'Beeja'. While travelling through the hills, she came across a sign on a tree that read: 'I was once a seed that held its ground.' Those words stirred her imagination, eventually blossoming into a full-fledged work. When she shared the idea with her long-time creative collaborator Sumantra Ghoshal, he envisioned it through nine poems that became the script of 'Beeja'. And just as the tree, Malavika remains rooted even as she branches out with fresh ideas.

'Beeja - Earth Seed' will be staged on March 28, 6.30 p.m. at Kalakshetra.



Legacy of compassion A 1979 photograph of the Ramakrishna Mission Students' Home at Mylapore. PHOTO: THE HINDU ARCHIVES

The act of giving

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Besides Ramanujachariar's colleagues, the Madras Secretariat Party comprised members such as renowned violinist Parur Anantharaman and several residents of the Students' Home such as Mannargudi Sambasiva Bhagavathar, who later became a noted harikatha exponent, and Anna N. Subramanian, who went to become a renowned author of religious books. In his reminiscences, noted philosopher TMP Mahadevan, who was also a resident of the Home in the 1920s, states that rehearsals used to be held in the campus on Sunday mornings and were much awaited occasions.

In December 1936, Ramanujachariar got together a group of actors from the Madras Secretariat Party, the Suguna Vilasa Sabha and a few other amateur drama troupes under the banner of The Madras Premier Amateurs and went on a tour of the Malay states to stage a series of performances to raise funds for the Students' Home. The arrangements had been made by an advance party, led by Rao

Bahadur M R Ramaswamy Sivan, who had retired as the first Indian Principal of the Agricultural College at Coimbatore. It was not Ramanujachariar's first fundraising venture in the region though. Besides theatre, he was a well-known figure in the world of Carnatic music (his contributions to the field have been well-documented) and counted several legends of the art form amongst his friends, one of them being Musiri Subramania Iyer. In February 1935, he had organised a tour of Subramania Iyer to Malaya.

Over the course of three weeks in January 1937, the troupe staged 15 performances across



When Vivekananda was given a grand reception in the city in February 1897 upon his return from the West, Ramanujachariar got an opportunity to closely interact with him and was drawn into the Ramakrishna movement.

all important centres of the Malay states such as Malacca, Seremban, Kuala Lumpur, Klang, Penang, Ipoh and Singapore. The plays performed included *Nandanar*, *Leela Sukhar*, *Raja Bhakti* and *Rama, the Ideal Son*. The tour was a grand success. In 1940, the Madras Secretariat Party embarked on Bombay tour, staging four performances to raise funds. A curtain-raiser for the tour, which appeared in the *Bombay Chronicle* stated that the troupe had staged 198 performances up to that point since its inception, out of which 172 had been for the benefit of the Students' Home, and rest being for causes such as flood relief, anti-tuberculosis fund and girls education. According to the book *A Palace for the Poor*, which profiles the history of the Students' Home, the total funds collected through dramas staged by the Secretariat Party exceeded ₹ 5 Lakhs, which went towards the corpus of the institution. In the 1940s, Ramanujachariar founded and mentored the Ramakrishna Kripa Amateurs, through which he continued his journey of fund-raising through theatre. Ramanujachariar passed away in November 1956.

CULTUREBRIEFS



Vocal concerts

Madhuradhvani will feature the following concerts at Arkay Convention Centre, Mylapore. Schedule: March 28, 6.15 p.m.: T.V.S. Mahadevan with B.U. Ganesh Prasad (violin), B.

Ganapathyraman (mridangam) and Prasanna Hariharan (ghatam). March 29, 6.15 p.m.: Series 11 of 'Ekaika raga kritis of Tyagaraja' will feature T.N.S. Krishna's vocal solo with B.U. Ganesh Prasad (violin), Shertalai R. Ananthakrishnan (mridangam) and Madipakkam Murali (ghatam).

Hamsadhvani's 36th annual music festival will feature the following concerts at Youth Hostel, Adyar. Details: March 28, 6.15 p.m.: Akkarai Sisters with Sruthi Sarathy (violin), S. Sundarkumar (mridangam) and S. Karthick (ghatam). March 29, 6.15 p.m.: K.S. Vishnudev (vocal) with Sruthi Sarathy (violin), K.V. Prasad (mridangam) and B.S. Purushotham (kanjira).



Revisiting classics

As part of World Theatre day and to celebrate veteran actor R.S. Manohar's centenary, Kartik Fine Arts in association with Dr. Shivprasad's Nataka Kavalar Chemmal R.S. Manohar's NXGs has organised a special programme that will revisit some of the classic plays of veteran actor. Highlights of his popular stage plays will be presented by S. Shivprasad, Sruthi and team today at Narada Gana Sabha. Time: 6.45 p.m.



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Harmony of Hope, Symphony of Sustenance.

How American textile expert Judy Frater, who moved to Kutch 30 years ago, helped rebuild the Rabaris’ craft tradition into a thriving creative economy

Designs from the desert



Malini White

In the latest segment of the International Music & Arts Society’s heritage lecture, held at Bangalore International Centre, American social entrepreneur, author, and expert in textile arts Judy Frater spoke about her latest book *Artisans by Design: An Odyssey of Education for Textile Artisans in India*. Clad in an elegant handloom sari, each slide she presented unfolded as a chapter in her passionate journey – a reflection of her deep bond with the craft, and her affection for the artisans who create it.

With a Masters in Anthropology and Museum Studies, Judy became the associate curator at the Textile Museum in Washington in 1989. The next year, she received Fulbright and Ford Foundation Fellowships to travel to India. Judy’s slight frame and diminutive stature belie her tenacity and conviction to live in Kutch’s harsh landscape for 30 years. She learnt Gujarati to

communicate with the Rabaris, a nomadic tribal community known for its rich craft heritage. She researched their cultural history and developed programmes for these artisans to connect them to the contemporary world. For this purpose, she co-founded the Kala Raksha Trust in 1993.

Rabari embroidery was executed by different ethnic groups, some nomadic. So, the work emerged as more than just skills – it embodied heritage, craft and communication. Judy realised that one could “read” the embroidery, as their verbal stories unfolded on the fabric. Her collected samples are now considered a precious resource in the Kala Raksha Museum in Bhuj, Gujarat. She started it in 1996.

Judy went on to establish the Kala Raksha Vidhyalaya in 2005. It is the first design school for traditional artisans, which educates them in market-appropriate innovation. Its aim was designed as a year-long course, structured across six intensive sessions spread over two weeks. She hoped the transformative

effect of education would empower these craftspeople. Their needs and inputs were prioritised, ensuring they were invested in the process of setting up the course. Her wonderfully structured classes brought out the best of their creativity and potential. While admissions were open only to practising craftsmen, the focus was also to improve their lives by offering guidance on diet and health.

In the design course, colour, motif, pattern, stitches were made accessible to students. Master-artisan advisors guided students to begin by studying their own traditions. Despite being restricted by culture to social discourse within their own community, the students flourished with encouragement and the comfort of working with their own people. Judy was astonished by the talents that

emerged and the manner in which they valued creative innovation.

Her guidance emphasised innovation within tradition, preserving and strengthening traditional elements in contemporary forms. This approach encouraged the students to resist designs imposed on them by design graduates or marketing men, eager to exploit the cache of the handmade, to satisfy the market.

Judy has concerns for the sustenance of these fragile communities that seem caught in a



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JUDY FRATER

Craft tales (Clockwise from left) Natural iron acetate dye being applied on a printed fabric; Rabari women at Kala Raksha Vidhyalaya; an elderly woman doing hand embroidery; and Judy Frater. PHOTOS COURTESY: KALA RAKSHA VIDHYALAYA, JUDY FRATER AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



time-warp. She hoped Nature and heritage continues to be their source of inspiration. “It’s so important to hold a piece of craft; it can tell you so much – much like holding a seashell: feeling its texture, shape, structure, colour, and even hearing and smelling it,” says Judy, who is keen on getting the younger generation in these communities to continue the family occupation.

According to Judy, craftspeople are not impervious to the world around them. Sometimes they incorporate non-traditional subjects such as lorries and airplanes into their craft. “The challenge lies in finding the appropriate traditional expression for the modern. They also react to changes in their

environment. For instance, the Kutch earthquake was depicted in an embroidery panel.”

Judy has contributed significantly to create international awareness of the craft. By introducing craftspeople to city museums, boutiques and fashion shows, and showing them how the larger world values their work, she has fostered their self-respect and pride. Taking advantage of Kutch’s popularity as a tourist destination, visitors can now join workshops conducted by these craftspeople.

For all her achievements, Judy remains self-effacing, focused on sharing her knowledge and experience, and eager to find new horizons in her love of traditional designs.

Neeta Lal

In many ways, Anisa Qureshi has spent her life at the intersection of rhythm and storytelling – two worlds shaped profoundly by her father, tabla maestro Zakir Hussain. Now 50, and preparing to be part of a special festival in Delhi, celebrating his life and legacy, Anisa stands not just as his daughter, but as a creative force in her own right – one who is carrying his ethos into new artistic frontiers.

A producer, director and creative strategist, Anisa’s career has unfolded across film, music, gaming and interactive entertainment. She has held influential roles at major global companies such as 2K Games and Electronic Arts, where she worked on cross-platform storytelling and audience engagement – blending narrative with emerging technology long before it became an industry shorthand. Her early work began with Waterborne, a project that found a home on the Sundance Channel, setting the tone for a career that would fluidly move between independent storytelling and large-scale production.

As a director, her documentary *Zakir Hussain - Sessions* premiered at the Mill Valley Film Festival in 2014 – offered audiences an intimate window into her father’s artistry.

Yet, for all her professional accomplishments, it is her bond with her father that forms the emotional core of her story. “The memories of him are all like shining stars. He was so intuitive – he could feel all of our moods and just wanted to care for us,” says Anisa, whose mother is Italian-American Kathak dancer and record label owner, Antonia Minnecola.

Those memories are not grand, distant recollections of a global icon, but deeply human, tender moments. She recalls a night when her infant daughter Zara wouldn’t sleep. Exhausted, Anisa had drifted off, only to wake up and find her father gently holding and rocking the baby in the stillness of the night. “I walked into the living room and



When echoes endure
Ustad Zakir Hussain; and (below) Anisa with her parents. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Beats and bonding

What it means to grow up in the shadow and light of a legend — Anisa Qureshi on her father, Ustad Zakir Hussain

there was dad holding her. He looked at me and silently gestured me to go back to bed.”

That presence – so often described by those who knew him – was as defining as his virtuosity. “He was always flying in and out,” she adds, “but when he was with us, he was all ours.”

Unlike many children of legends, she was never pressured to follow in his footsteps. “He knew the road would be tough and felt it had to be a calling.” When she did express interest, he embraced it fully. “When I was ready, he was incredibly generous in teaching me. We had beautiful sessions together.”

Ultimately, her calling led her elsewhere. “I was not called to be a

professional musician,” she reflects, “but I have a deep love for music, dance and theatre. Choosing film and entertainment strategy felt natural and he was very supportive.”

That path, though not musical in the traditional sense, has always been infused with sound. “Music is part of my DNA. I grew up in recording studios and soundchecks, exposed to so many styles because of him.” That immersion shaped her instincts. “For my work, my father would say, ‘Anisa, you know what it’s supposed to sound like.’ That stayed with me. Learning to ‘talk music’ and become friends with it was different for me – but it was always there.”

Her childhood reads like a tapestry of artistic immersion. She and her sister spent their early years backstage at concerts, often left to explore freely while their father performed. On Mount Tamalpais in California, they would lie on the grass listening to music drift through open-air venues, or invent playful schemes such as selling band merchandise with made-up slogans for his fusion group,

Rhythm Experience. “We got completely into it –making up songs and slogans to sell the shirts,” she recalls with a smile. “At the end of the night, he came to check on us and we were still at it. We all had a good laugh.”

Even now, as she navigates life after his passing, those memories remain vivid anchors. Early this year, Anisa attended the Grammy Awards, an event her father had graced many times and for which he had received multiple nominations. “He was nominated for three Grammys this year, and we went in his honour,” she says. “To be there without him was so strange.” The absence was deeply

felt. “His family and friends, along with so many artistes and producers miss him so much.”

And yet, she is clear: his legacy is far from static. “Though there are albums, recordings and teachings still to be released, his passing left a void in the music world, and of course, in his family,” she says. “But he lives on in us, in so many musicians he mentored, in the music he created and in that smile that made everyone feel like they mattered.”

Her current work reflects that belief. She just wrapped up ‘Zakir Hussain Eternal’ at Carnegie Hall, a tribute concert featuring 30 artistes, timed to what would have been his 75th birthday. “It was a special show,” she says.

More significantly, she is spearheading the Zakir Hussain Institute of Music, a non-profit initiative dedicated to preserving and evolving his artistic vision. “Through music education, mentorship, events such as the Carnegie Hall, and the archives, we continue his mission,” she explains. “He believed in the transcendent power of music to unite people – and he proved it.”

That mission will come alive at ‘Ustad Zakir Hussain: The Way Forward’, a three-day homage organised by Kiran Nadar Museum of Art, at Sunder Nursery, in New Delhi from today till March 29, marking his 75th birth anniversary, an event Anisa will be an integral part of. More than a tribute, the festival seeks to celebrate his pioneering contributions to rhythm by bringing together master percussionists and admirers from around the world. The festival will also screen of Anisa’s film.

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ANISA QURESHI

